

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

NORTHEAST SWAG

From Margins to Mainstage

▲ **(L-R) PABE, MOYON, SASUM AND LUMI**

Gilithigreams, all-girl pop band from Arunachal Pradesh

THE HILLS ARE ALIVE WITH THEIR MUSIC

Q. You started your journey in Itanagar and today your songs are on national playlists. How did this journey unfold?
Lumi: It began with small performances and sharing our music online, reaching people beyond Arunachal Pradesh. Slowly, our music started getting noticed, and today, we are grateful that listeners across India are discovering us.

Q. How do you respond to comparisons with K-pop or other international trends?
Sasum & Moyon: Influence is natural in music and we listen to artistes from all over the world. But we never forget our roots. Our songs mix English and Hindi with our Nyishi language, which keeps our identity alive. The goal is to create something that feels authentic to us.

Q. You are an all-girl band, and the music world today is driven by algorithms, trends and social media. How difficult is it to survive in this environment?
Lumi & Moyon: The biggest challenge is staying consistent. Algorithms and trends change every day, but what matters is passion and hard work.

Q. Online criticism and trolling can be intense for young artistes. Has that changed the way you think about public life?
Lumi & Moyon: At first, negative comments can feel discouraging, but eventually you realise that criticism comes with visibility. We focus on constructive feedback.

Q. The Northeast is incredibly diverse. Does mainstream India still understand it little?
Moyon: Yes, there's a lot that people outside don't know. The Northeast has many different cultures. Through music and art, we hope people become curious about this diversity.